ALLAHU AKBAR

While the Jesuit priests were constructing their chapel and translating the gospel into Persian, another unusual text was being composed at Fatehpur Sikri. An anonymous Brahmin, at Akbar's request, had written a Sanskrit text called the *Allopanisad* (Allah's Upanishad). Riffing with unselfconscious candour on the meaning of the words 'Akbar' and 'Allahu Akbar', the text provocatively offered ambiguous interpretations of the phrases that included the Mughal Padshah's name. At the same time, mutinies broke out in Bengal and Bihar, ostensibly as a righteous movement against the rumours of un-Islamic practices being carried out by the Padshah at Fatehpur Sikri. But the cause of Islam was just a convenient rallying point for disgruntled officers, mostly Central Asian Turani noblemen and some Persians, who were deeply resentful of the measures taken by Akbar to reduce the rampant corruption and nepotism in his administration, and to centralize the fiscal system. These measures were loathed by some noblemen who, in earlier times, had been the favoured elite backbone of Mughal nobility.

As we have seen, Akbar was constantly trying to tighten the empire's revenue and administrative system. Dissatisfied with the way in which land revenue was being assessed, Akbar had ordered all lands in the central Indo-Gangetic provinces to revert to the khalisa, the crown lands, in 1575. For five years, mansabdars were paid in cash from the imperial treasury while the lands in the newly acquired territories were carefully measured following Raja Todar Mal's system, crop yields were noted down, and tax rates accurately determined. These new figures were added to older measurements and a new assessment generated. On the basis of the average prices of crops in the previous ten years, the tax claim was now fixed for each crop in each region. No longer would tax be calculated on the basis of seasonal prices and a direct communication between the government and the ryots had been established. Akbar then reassigned a large amount of the lands back to mansabdars but retained lands yielding about 25 per cent of the overall yield for the needs of his own household. Khalisa land was retained in the most productive areas, providing the emperor with some